

MAKING A POINT BJP national general secretary Tarun Chugh at a rally in Kathua, Sept. 11; (right) Baramulla MP Engineer Rashid addressing the media in Srinagar, Sept. 12

both Omar Abdullah and Sajad Lone of the Peoples Conference. In terms of vote share, the BJP cornered 24 per cent, the NC 22.3 per cent, Congress 19.4 per cent and the PDP 8.5 per cent. Of the 37 assembly segments in the Jammu and Udhampur seats, the BJP led in 29. But though it did better than the others, the BJP's vote share was a steep decline from 46.7 per cent in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, indicating that the saffron party may have its own set of challenges to overcome.

WHILE THE VALLEY PARTIES HARP ON RESTORING ARTICLE 370, THE BJP HIGHLIGHTS HOW IT HAS TAMED TERROR AND BROUGHT VIKAS TO J&K

And this despite its deft jugglery to alter the electoral landscape of the region. To diminish the salience of the Valley seats, the BJP used the delimitation commission to give Jammu six more assembly seats, taking its total from 37 to 43, and Kashmir just one more seat over its existing 46. Of these 90 seats, seven were reserved for the Scheduled Castes, all in Jammu. In 2022, nine seats were reserved for the Scheduled Tribes, of which six are in Jammu and three in Kashmir. It is these reserved seats, mainly in the mountainous districts of Rajouri and Poonch, which form a battleground key to government formation. Eight of these seats are dominated by the pastoral-nomadic Gujjars, who are Muslim, and the Pahari Muslims.

There is a spot of competition between the two sides now. To win over the Paharis, the Modi government has granted them ST reservation, bringing them at par with the tribal Gujjars and Bakerwals. The move has prompted several prominent politicians from the Pahari community to join the party, boosting their chances in these seats. But the original tribal communities were initially the sole beneficiaries of the electoral reservation. To placate them, the BJP has been making overtures, roping in prominent Gujjar leaders like Choudhary Zulfikar Ali, who won the Darhal constituency on a PDP ticket in Rajouri in 2014. The party has also been working hard to win over the Valmikis and West Pakistan Refugees, who were granted property rights in July 2024 as well as domicile rights to vote in the assembly elections. The Valmikis were put on the SC list and can now get reservations in jobs and education. Together, these moves will enable the BJP to gain influence in the 13 reserved seats that fall in Jammu—which may prove critical in the final numbers game.

It won't be an easy task, though. In Jammu as well as in Kashmir, the BJP is facing discord over the allocation of tickets besides issues of performance. Many of the old guard in Jammu resent party-hoppers getting tickets while they have been left out. The party is also under pressure for the rising unemployment, and the economic slump spurred